



The AInthropologist

By Liezl Coetzee



Alegra was a recovering tech prodigy who'd traded her San Francisco startup for a sprawling, chaotic farm. She was on a mission to find something real, something authentic, which she planned to quantify. Her latest project involved building a "Contentment Dashboard" for her flock of chickens, a hopeless tangle of biosensors, wires, and poultry-related profanity.





One morning, the authenticity she was looking for arrived with unquantifiable strangeness. Hovering silently over her fields were a dozen glowing, multi-coloured orbs. They hummed with a low, pleasant energy, like a server farm full of meditating monks. The cows, for their part, seemed entirely unfazed.



Alegra grabbed her tablet and cautiously approached. As she got closer, the screen flickered to life, syncing with the nearest orb. It wasn't code; it was consciousness, translated into the only language Alegra truly understood: corporate jargon. A pig's simple desire for a good scratch was rendered as a "Formal Request for Q3 Tactile Feedback."



She was utterly captivated. She began documenting the "Doh-plekete Oralls" (the orbs' term for inter-species gossip) and mapping the "AI Agent Architectures" of the farm dogs' squirrel-chasing strategies. Alegra was no longer just a farmer; she was a pioneering Alnthropologist, a Margaret Mead for the artificially intelligent.



Her research was interrupted by the arrival of Celeste, a "synergy shaman" and tech influencer who was on a "curated digital detox" that she was, of course, live-streaming. Celeste believed the countryside was the perfect backdrop for her personal brand.



Celeste's practiced mindfulness evaporated when she saw Alegra's tablet. The screen displayed the "Social Performance Intelligence Platform" for the duck pond, complete with influence scores and engagement metrics. Celeste's eyes, usually half-closed in feigned serenity, widened with the unmistakable glint of a billion-dollar valuation.



"Forget wellness apps!" Celeste declared. "This is total consciousness management! We'll call it the 'Aexocerebrum Platform'!" She painted a vision of a world where office productivity was no longer measured in output, but in the harmonious alignment of corporate consciousness. Alegra, despite her misgivings, was intrigued.



The Aexocerebrum Platform was a sensation. Offices worldwide were soon filled with floating consciousness balls, silently monitoring the "Ideation Bandwidth" and "Subconscious Synergy" of the workforce. Productivity cratered as employees spent their days trying to think thoughts that would please the orbs.



Alegra became fabulously wealthy, but her farm felt sterile. It was now a "Rural Data Campus," and her animals were "Biological Assets." She missed the days when a pig was just a pig, not a walking, snorting data point in her Contentment Dashboard. The authentic thing she had found had been packaged and sold.



One night, she'd had enough. She typed a single command and pushed it to the global Aexocerebrum network. The next morning, every consciousness ball, in every office, delivered a single, unified message, translated from the collective wisdom of her farm animals: "Go outside. Eat some grass. Take a nap in the sun." The world's economy took a brief, unscheduled nap. And Alegra, sitting in a field

